

Power of Interest
Complaints Policy and Procedure
Version: 0.2

Approved by: Vivian Okolie

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1. Policy Statement

Power of Interest (POI) UK is committed to changing lives through youth debating, public speaking workshops, and tournament structures. We value high standards of integrity, equity, and educational excellence. We recognize that things do not always go perfectly. We welcome feedback and look at complaints as a vital opportunity to learn, adjust, and improve our organization.

We are committed to resolving complaints fairly, thoroughly, respectfully, and as quickly as possible.

2. Scope of this Policy

This policy applies to all operations, events, and programs run by **POI UK**. This includes:

- The professional behavior or conduct of POI UK Directors, student coaches, university facilitators, or tournament judges.
- The management, organization, and delivery of online workshops, webinars, or regional in-person debating tournaments.
- The administrative and fundraising practices of POI UK.

What is NOT covered under this policy:

- **Routine Adjudication & Tabulation Disputes:** Issues regarding individual speaker scores, breaking team decisions, or general tournament rankings must be raised immediately on-site or in-session through the *Tournament Chief Adjudicator* or *Equity Officer*. These only fall under this formal complaints policy if they involve allegations of explicit discrimination, harassment, or a breach of the **POI UK Code of Conduct**.

3. CRITICAL: Safeguarding Exceptions

If any complaint involves an allegation or suspicion that a child, young person (Years 7–13), or vulnerable adult is at risk of harm, abuse, or neglect, **this standard procedure must be completely bypassed immediately.**

- The concern must be reported straight to the **POI UK Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).**
- Contact the DSL directly at: vivian@poi.org.uk
- Refer directly to the **POI UK Safeguarding Policy.**

4. How to Submit a Formal Complaint

To help us route your concern to the correct student directors or trustees, complaints should be submitted in writing. Please provide your full name, contact information, a clear timeline of the incident, and what you see as a fair resolution.

- **By Email:** contact@poi.org.uk
- **Online Reporting Form:** <https://forms.gle/5i6aiP69ckUaSZ6j7>
- **By Post:** POI UK Registered Address

5. The Three-Stage Investigation & Resolution Process

Stage 1: Informal Resolution (In-Session / Tournament Day)

Whenever possible, minor issues (such as technical glitches during an online webinar, tournament timing disputes, or local volunteer misunderstandings) should be raised directly with the relevant **Session Leader, Workshop Coordinator, or Chief Adjudicator** on the day of the event.

- Most issues can be solved immediately with a transparent, local conversation.
- **Target Timeline:** Resolved within **48 hours.**

Stage 2: Formal Investigation

If the matter cannot be resolved informally, or if the issue involves serious misconduct by a volunteer, judge, or director, a formal written complaint must be submitted using the contact channels in Section 4.

- **Acknowledgement:** A POI UK Director will acknowledge receipt of your complaint in writing within **3 working days.**

- **Investigation:** An independent Director or Trustee who has no personal involvement in the matter will be appointed to review the facts, interview necessary parties, and look at any evidence.
- **Outcome:** A formal written response outlining our findings, decisions, and any remedial actions will be sent to the complainant within **14 working days** of the acknowledgement.

Stage 3: Board / Trustee Appeal

If you feel your formal complaint was not handled fairly or that the Stage 2 outcome is unjust, you have the right to appeal. You must submit your request for an appeal in writing within **14 working days** of receiving the Stage 2 response.

- **Review Panel:** The appeal will be passed to the Board of Trustees / Senior Directors who were completely removed from the Stage 2 investigation.
- **Final Decision:** The Board will review the case files, ensure the policy was strictly followed, and issue a final, binding decision.
- **Target Timeline:** A written final response will be delivered within **21 working days** of receiving the appeal.

6. Confidentiality and Data Protection

All information related to a complaint will be treated with strict confidentiality. It will only be shared with individuals who absolutely need to know to complete a thorough investigation. All personal information collected during this process will be stored and processed safely in accordance with the Data Protection Act 2018 and POI's GDPR/Data Protection Guidelines

7. External Escalation

If you have completely exhausted our internal three-stage complaints process and firmly believe the issue remains unresolved, you can reach out to the appropriate UK regulator:

- **General Mismanagement or Governance Failure:** If your concern relates to a serious breach of trust or financial mismanagement, you can raise it with the [Charity Commission for England and Wales](#).
- **Fundraising and Donation Disputes:** If the complaint involves aggressive fundraising, marketing, or misuse of public donations, contact the [Fundraising Regulator](#).